Emma Goldman: Love, Anarchy and Other Affairs

By Jessica Litwak

INTRODUCTION

NARRATOR: SEPTEMBER 9, 1901. Three days ago President William McKinley was shot. The assassin was quickly apprehended. His name is Leon Czolgosz. He has confessed to being an anarchist. He stated that he became an anarchist through the influence of EMMA GOLDMAN, whose writings and lectures incited him to commit this act of violence against the President of the United States. Vice President Roosevelt has stated that the nation will take action to stamp out anarchy all together. A nationwide search for Emma Goldman commenced. In Chicago, homes of several anarchists were raided and six men known to be friendly with Emma Goldman were arrested and charged with conspiracy, but the woman anarchist could not be found. However, this evening the authorities have traced Emma Goldman to Chicago-to an apartment building at 308 Sheffield Avenue. Thirteen officers have surrounded the premises. Fully armed, the officers watch the windows of the third floor apartment and wait for…Emma Goldman: Love, Anarchy and Other Affairs. By Jessica Litwak

EMMA: The strangest thing just happened to me. I was walking through the crowds with my bag held up to my face, to protect it. So if I got hit, my face would remain unharmed. No scars. I can't believe it, I was protecting my face. Such feminine vanity. What would Sasha say? Hello. I am.. . Smith. E. G. Smith. At least that's the name I've been using recently. This is not my room. This is my friend Max's room. Max has agreed to let me stay here tonight. My lover is in prison and I have been recently accused of conspiring to assassinate the President of the United States. All over the streets they are saying, "Anarchists should be exterminated. Their tongues cut out, their carcasses soaked in oil and burnt alive." Just this afternoon I was riding the streetcar with this charming young lady. She turned to me and said, "Have you read the morning papers? This Emma Goldman is a beast. A blood thirsty monster; she should have been locked up

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

long ago." "Locked up nothing," said the gentleman standing behind us, "She should have her heart cut out and fed to my dog." I nodded politely. . . After all, what do I know of Emma Goldman. I'm Smith. Just plain old E. G. This poor boy. . . this. . .assassin. I wonder what drove him to do this thing? He is reported to have said, "I did it for the working people." Sasha also did something once for the working people. . . but the people are asleep. They are indifferent and afraid. . . I promised Max I would escape to Canada in the morning. . . Max says I have no business being in Chicago . . . he says the police are thirsty for my blood. . . Well, things have been worse. After all, Sasha-that is, Alexander Berkman-is in prison-he's been in prison now for ten years. I don't like to think about it. Perhaps I should have a bath, now. . . you know what Max said? Max said if anyone was to come here tonight, I am to say, "I am the maid." The maid. . . Isn't that what they called Joan of Arc? Shall I tell you a story? To pass the time till Max comes. Yes. Let's see tonight is September 9th, 1901 in Chicago, America, I am hiding, NO. . . waiting, NO. . . relaxing at Max's house, and I will tell you a little story. . . My story. . . A love story. I was born in Kovno, Lithuania on June 27, 1869. I came to America-to Rochester, New York at the age of 16. I worked in a factory making two dollars and fifty cents a week.. At this time, all over the country labor strikes were breaking out-the people were demanding an 8 hour day-on May 4, 1887 a mass meeting of workers was called in Chicago's Haymarket Square. It was addressed by several leading anarchist speakers. It was a quiet and orderly meeting until police burst in and began beating people with clubs. A bomb sailed through the air killing several policemen. All of the anarchists were arrested and on November II, Friday, Black Friday. . . the day I became an anarchist. . . I was walking home from a meeting with my sister Helena. . . I was walking home from a meeting with my sister Helena. . . We have just heard the news. The brave anarchists have been hanged. One of them has

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

committed suicide in his cell. Helena is crying, and I am in shock. We go to my father's house. I am in the kitchen staring at the tea kettle. Everyone is talking about the news from Chicago. I know they were innocent-five of them dead, arrested and hung. . . I hear a woman's shrill voice from across the room: "Those anarchists were murderers-they deserve to be hung!" One leap and I'm at her throat. They pull me back. "The child's gone crazy." I pick up a pitcher of water and I throw it in her face. "Get out. Get out or I will kill you!" My father slaps me. Helena is crying. "I know they were innocent! Five of them dead!" I fall on the floor in a dead faint. They put me to bed. I woke up early. My head was clear for the first time. I had the distinct sensation that something new and wonderful had happened to me. I had an ideal, a reason for living. I decided to devote my life to anarchism.

August 15th, 1889. The day I met Alexander Berkman. I arrive in New York City. I have left everything behind me to start a new life. I wander around, and on Third Street I meet a man I have seen in Rochester. He takes me to Sach's Cafe-a gathering place for artists, and revolutionists and workers. . . we sit down at a table. . . I hear a loud voice: "Bring me an extra large steak. An extra large cup of coffee!" "Who is that glutton?" I ask. "That is Alexander Berkman. He never has much money, but when he does he eats Sach's right out of food. He's a very serious young anarchist. One of those obsessive types. The cause above all else you know the kind. . . shall I introduce him to you?" We approach the table. He stands up to shake my hand. "Alexander Berkman, Emma Goldman." He is a boy of eighteen but with the neck and chest of a giant. Big shoulders. Brown eyes. Very severe forehead. Somehow a little frightening. We look at each other. "Hello." Very nervous. "Pleased to meet you." I am smiling, I don't know why.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

1890. Sasha. After one meeting of the anarchists, Sasha and I walked home in silence. When we got to the house where I lived. . . my whole body began to shake. Like a fever. I looked at Sasha. He came upstairs. I had a very narrow bed. We were squished together in the darkness. He whispered soft Russian words into my ear. . . that made me drowsy., . I began to drift into a dreamy sleep. . . then suddenly I was roused by an electric current rushing through me... a soft, shy hand. . . trembling. . . touching me tenderly. . . I reached out for the hand. . . we were in a wild embrace. A terrific pain-like a sharp knife. . . breaking through everything that had been dormant, unconscious and suppressed. . . in the morning I was still reaching out--eagerly, hungrily. . . seeking. . . he was sleeping now. . . and I raised myself up on one elbow and watched him . . . the face of this boy that attracted me and repelled me at the same time. . . he was so hard and yet so tender. I kissed his thick black hair and then I fell asleep beside him. . . That was the first time. Sasha is upstairs building a bomb. He's never done it before, but we have a copy of *The Science of Revolutionary Warfare*. . . and it gives a pretty good description.

May 1892. Henry Clay Frick. Big Boss. Carnegie Steel Mills. Wages are cut. Workers strike. Mills close. Workers attacked. Beaten and killed. Henry Clay Frick. An infamous piece of scum. Sasha has decided to kill him.Sasha knows where he can get dynamite-from a man on Staten Island. Sasha says. . . "I have waited all my life for the sublime moment to serve the cause. To give my life for the people." Sasha says although he will live long enough to justify his act in court, he knows he will be condemned to death. "I have waited all my life for the sublime moment to serve the cause. To give my life. . . " Oh Sasha. The more you talk, the sicker I feel. I am oblivious of everything else--Cause, Duty, Message. . . what do these things mean compared with the force of our love?-Does our

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

three years together mean so little to you that you can sit there calmly expecting me to go on living after you've been blown to bits or strangled to death? I will go with you, Sasha. . . I can help. Besides, I simply must go with you... do you understand, Sasha? An argument ensues. Finally he agrees to let me go with him-at least as far as Pittsburgh. . . on the train. The bomb didn't go off. . . and if the test bomb doesn't go off, that means the second bomb made out of the same materials won't go off either. We have lost forty dollars and a week of our time. Now I'll never be able to go with Sasha-we don't have enough money for train fare. . . we have to raise the money to buy a gun. So how does one go about raising quick cash? How does a woman, alone in New York City, go about raising a large amount of cash quickly? How far does one go for the man one loves? For the cause? Well, I got the idea from Dostoyevsky. In *Crime and Punishment,* Sonia became a prostitute to support her little brothers and sisters. . . and when the men came, she lay on her cot with her shoulders twitching and her face to the wall. If sensitive Sonia could sell her body, if Sasha can give his life to the cause, then certainly I can . . .The question is, am I attractive enough for the men on the street? I look tired. But my complexion is good. I have nice hair. I'm too large in the hips for my age, but I'm a Jew, I look like my grandmother-it's something to be proud of! . . . Anyway, I could always wear a corset and high heels. Oy.

July 16th, 1892. I am walking up and down Fourteenth Street. I join the long procession of girls I have seen so often. I try to mimic their calm. The weather doesn't seem to affect them. They disappear into doorways with men and then reappear again. . . each time a man comes by me, I get nauseous. . . and then I panic as he passes me by . . . I have to raise the money to buy a gun! It's 11:00 and still I've had no luck. Finally an elderly man in a pinstripe suit approaches me

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

. . . he beckons me to follow him into a cafe... He orders two glasses of wine. "I don't know what drove you to the streets, but I'm sure it wasn't looseness, or lack of excitement in your personal life."

"Many girls are driven to it by economic necessity!" I told him.

"I'm not interested in economic necessity, or in the reason you were out there, I'll just tell you one thing: There's nothing in prostitution unless you have the knack for it . . . and you most certainly do not." He put a ten dollar bill down on the table. "Now go home," he said.

"Don't you want me to do something? Take off my clothes or something?"

He smiled. "You are a sweet kid, but you are silly and stupid, and immature."

"I was twenty-three last month!"

He laughed at me. I ran all the way home. With ten dollars for the gun. I cling to Sasha. He is already on the train. I am on the lower step. . . his face is bent low to mine. . . he is holding me: "My sailor girl." . . . the train moves. . . "Comrade, you will be with me to the very last. Steam. Wheels turning. He loosens his hold and gently helps me down. . . I have to jump a little off the step. . . I'm running, waving and crying after the departing train. . . Sasha, Sashenka! Arms outstretched. A life is being snatched away. . .

July 23rd. Saturday. I ran after the departing train. We only had money for one ticket. He said only one person was needed for the job. He barged into Frick's office and shot the bastard three times. In the neck, in the shoulder. There was blood. Men ran in. They took the gun. He had a knife. Poison dagger. He stabbed Frick in the leg. They took the knife. He put something in his mouth. They pinned him to the ground. They pried open his jaws. Candy, he said. There was a capsule of fulminate of mercury. All he had to do was chew on the capsule and the whole room would have blown up and everyone in it. They held his head

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

back. They removed the capsule. They beat him unconscious. Sasha has been in prison now for ten years, many of them in solitary confinement-in a dungeon. And Frick survived and became a hero in the press and the public turned against the workers and the strike was broken. It was said we set back the American labor movement forty years.

I am in the visitor's room in the Western Pennsylvania Penitentiary. I am frightened. I haven't seen Sasha in months. I am waiting and then all of a sudden he's there. In a grey outfit. Looking thin. He has lost some hair. The guard is watching us. I am shaking in the knees. But I keep my hands steady so Sasha can't see. . . ah Sasha. Hello, my love. . . He won't look at me. . . He seems weak. The guard thinks I'm his sister. We sit together on the wooden bench. He has changed. The shoulders hunched, the spirit broken. The brown eyes full of despair. The guard is pacing. Door slams somewhere in the hallway. Sasha jerks his head up. Our eyes meet. I am smiling at him. I don't know why. The guard comes to stand over us. "Your time's up." Sasha jumps to his feet. I feel so helpless. He kisses me, and I feel something pass from his mouth into mine. . . Then he is gone as quickly as he came. In my mouth was a message from Sasha. It said that I should go to Inspector Reed and try to get a second visitor's pass for the next day. But by the next day my identity had been discovered and no one was in the mood for doing Emma Goldman any favors. . . No, after that day I didn't see Sasha again for nine years.

I wonder where Max is? He should be home by now. I only came to Chicago because so many of my friends were being arrested-just for having their names linked with mine. I thought perhaps I would turn myself in but then Max said. . . I don't like to think about it. Sometimes I wonder if my life has been wonh

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

living up to this point. Has anything been heard? Has the world shifted even a little? Here I am pretending to be a maid in someone's apartment, getting ready to run off to Canada like a horse thief. I don't know. . .

If you're buried under a ton of din, isn't it better to hack away at it with the heel of your shoe rather than turn away from the task for lack of a shovel? .., Isn't it. better to fight for breath than to resign oneself to suffocation? Anarchism is a process, not a finality. Oh Sasha. I am trying to be brave. I paid the first due for my opinions in 1893 . . . with a year's free residence at Blackwell's Island Penitentiary. I was arrested after a speech I gave at Union Square. They grabbed me as I left the meeting. There were three of them. They held my hands behind my back and pushed me against a wall. "Why am I being arrested?" I asked them. No response. "What am I being arrested for?!" "For being Emma Goldman," one of them replied. . .

Well, if Max doesn't show up soon, I'll go to bed. . . I have a big trip ahead of me in the morning; I don't particularly want to go to Canada, but 1 guess it's the best thing. 1 can't hide here forever using a fake name---especially Smith. 1 suppose I'll have that bath now. . . there's nothing like warm water to calm the nerves. . . Oh, I'm not frightened. I've had a lovely evening. . . I've thought of Sasha... it's so good to be able to look back, to forgive oneself. . . and to feel proud of the things one has accomplished. But even more, to feel proud of the pain, and the silliness. . . and the lovemaking. These are trying but wonderful times. There is great work to do. Be brave beloved comrades. Our enemy is fighting a losing battle. They are of the dying past. . . We, are of the glowing future.

NARRATOR: At 10:00 on the night of September 9th, 1901, Emma Goldman was arrested

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

for her alleged complicity in the plot to assassinate President McKinley. She was captured at the home of an anarchist friend, Mr. Max Baginski. At the time of the discovery of her whereabouts, Emma Goldman was taking a bath. There was a scratching at the window and then a crash of glass. She emerged from the bath in a house robe, to find an officer clutching the window ledge with one h and, and holding a gun in the other. The apartment, on the third floor of the building, had no fire escape. She reached towards the officer at the window, "Look out, you'll break your neck!" she recalled. He entered the room through the broken window and ran to the locked front door. He opened the door. Twelve officers crowded into the apartment. The chief officer, Captain Schueffler, grabbed Emma Goldman's arm. "Who are you?" he asked. "I am the maid," she replied. "Who lives here?" inquired the captain. There was no response. When further questioned as to the whereabouts of Emma Goldman, the alleged maid claimed to be a Swedish servant girl who did not speak English. The officers completed a thorough search of the apartment, finding no evidence, until one detective discovered a fountain pen on the floor... the pen was engraved with the name "Emma Goldman." The captain ordered three of his men to remain on the premises to await the return of the woman anarchist. Goldman realized the game was up. There was no way out. No sign of her friend returning home, no use keeping up her false identity. "Excuse me, officer," she said. All the policemen turned to look at her. . .

EMMA: I am Emma Goldman.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jessica Litwak
Book: Women Heroes: Six Short Plays from the Women's Project
ISBN: 0936839228
Publisher: Hal Leonard Corporation
Date (Month/Year): 1987

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY